LOVE KILLS

Tragic Romance / Supernatural Fiction

I first saw her in Wales in 1979, during the *Witch Hunt Season* tour.

What I didn’t know then was that the witch would be the one hunting me.

There she was among the crowd, staring straight at me with absolute confidence, dressed entirely in black as though she were attending a funeral. She looked like a black cat sitting perfectly still in the darkness.

Between her fingers was a long, slender cigarette. I would later learn they were Virginia Slims.

Our eyes met while I sang.

The crowd was losing its mind. My bandmates were throwing themselves around the stage. Everyone was moving, screaming, drinking, living as though tomorrow had never been invented.

Everyone except us.

For those few seconds, Isabella and I seemed to exist somewhere else entirely.

Still.

Mesmerized.

Living inside a moment that belonged to no one but us.

And for the briefest instant, I could have sworn the Earth had stopped turning just for the two of us.

After that night, I started seeing pieces of her in every woman I met.

Aurora had curls like hers. Claire had those same enormous, extraordinary eyes. Elena had a nose shaped almost exactly like hers.

But none of them were Isabella.

She had already taken possession of me.

My heart burned like one of those thin cigarettes between her fingers.

Our story didn't truly begin until I ran into her again by chance.

I was heading back to Jack's flat, where the band had gathered to discuss the next album. We'd run out of beer, so somebody had to go and pick up another six-pack.

Technically, I was the star. I wasn't supposed to be the one running errands.

Yet, for whatever reason, I volunteered.

Fate is a strange thing.

Think about it. What if I'd stayed behind? What if I'd sent somebody else?

I might never have had Izzy at all.

I was approaching the shop when I heard the sweetest voice I had ever heard in my life.

I knew immediately that it could belong to only one person.

"Excuse me. You wouldn't happen to have a spare cigarette, would you?"

I turned.

There she was.

I looked into her eyes and, with all the shameless confidence I possessed in those days, said:

"For a girl as beautiful as you, I'll buy the whole pack."

She tried not to smile.

She failed.

And God, what a smile it was.

Something inside me melted. It felt as though our souls had already begun moving toward one another, preparing to become something neither of us could separate again.

I bought her the pack and watched her pull out a cigarette and light it with effortless elegance.

As we were leaving, she suddenly stumbled.

I caught her before she hit the ground.

"You all right?"

"I'm fine."

She clearly wasn't.

She was painfully thin, and beneath the shop lights I noticed just how pale she was.

"You anaemic?"

She nodded.

"Eating disorder?"

Another nod.

"Both."

She brushed it aside and told me she'd be fine if she could just get something to drink.

So we sat on the ground outside the shop, and I handed her one of the beers.

We started talking.

There was nothing particularly dramatic about it at first. Just two people sitting outside a shop, drinking beer and smoking cigarettes.

But talking to Isabella felt like stepping into another world.

She could turn the most insignificant subject into the most fascinating conversation you'd ever had. Things that should have meant nothing suddenly seemed important when she spoke about them.

Hours disappeared.

Before either of us realised it, we'd spent the entire night talking. The beer was gone. We were nearly out of cigarettes.

The air had grown cold.

I took off my leather jacket and handed it to her.

"I'm fine," she protested.

"No, you're freezing."

"I'm not."

"Take the bloody jacket, Izzy."

Eventually, she did.

I told her she could return it whenever she wanted.

That was a lie.

Well, technically it wasn't.

I simply neglected to mention that I'd given it to her because I wanted to make absolutely certain I would see her again.